

THE MIRACLE MAN OF KIZHAKKAMBALAM

P.R. SREEJESH BECAME A NATIONAL SYMBOL OF OPTIMISM AND PRIDE WHEN HE STOOD IN THE GOAL. NOW THAT HE HAS BID FAREWELL TO THE SPORT, WE DECIPHER THE MAN HOCKEY LOVED BACK.

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If you asked a random Malayali kid to sketch a Kerala town, it would likely resemble Kizhakkambalam. With its narrow but well-laid-out roads winding through vast, sun-soaked paddy fields and algae-covered ponds, Kizhakkambalam perfectly fits the image. But this town, located on the outskirts of Kochi, has something unique about it.

It's probably the only place in Kerala where flex boards of Lionel Messi — and by extension, the Argentinian football team — are outnumbered by those of another sporting icon: P.R. Sreejesh, the state's only double Olympic medallist. Amidst the sea of greenery, Sreejesh's red-tinted home stands out, much like he distinguished himself in the Indian hockey team for nearly two decades in his goalkeeper's colours.

When *Sportstar* visited Sreejesh's home, his goalkeeping kit was laid out in the front yard under the blazing afternoon sun, almost as if to reinforce his

Bowing out on a high: P. R. Sreejesh, India's legendary hockey goalkeeper, ended his career with an Olympic medal from Paris.

THULASI KAKKAT

